Discover: The Moon's Journey

Today I can… ☐ State that the Moon orbits Earth in roughly a month. ☐ Explain that moonlight is reflected sunlight. ☐ Explain phases using our changing view of the lit half.

Feedback: ☐ VF ☐ WS ☐ I ☐ NS ☐ E ☐ R ☐ [//] ☐ [?] _____

Knowledge organiser

Learning goal

I can explain why the Moon appears to change shape as it orbits Earth.

Blue shows word meanings. Green shows key ideas.

Word and meaning

satellite — an object that orbits a planet

phase — the shape of the lit part of the Moon visible from Earth

orbit — a curved path around another body

reflected — light that changes direction from a surface

Key ideas

Torch is the Sun, ball is the Moon, observer is Earth. Keep the sunlight direction fixed.

Half the Moon is illuminated by the Sun. As it orbits, our view of the illuminated half changes.

When the visible lit half faces us, we see full Moon. When it faces away, we see new Moon.

Trace the light path: Sun → Moon → observer on Earth. Name the Sun as light source and the Moon as reflecting object.

Keep the claim fair

The model does not show realistic sizes, distances or the tilt of the Moon’s orbit.

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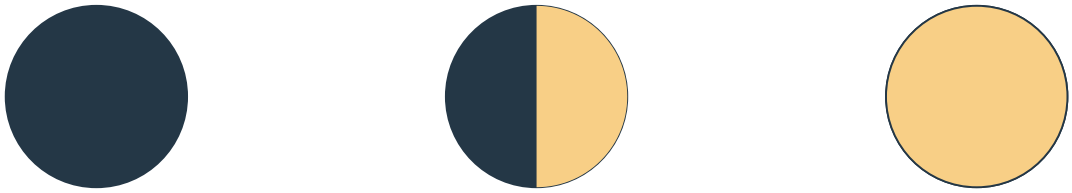
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The Moon's Journey

New, half and full are views from Earth. The Moon stays round; its visible lit part changes.

Orange shows the part seen lit. Dark blue shows the part not seen lit.



new Moon | half Moon | full Moon

Views from Earth; not to scale.

The ball stays round at every position.